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It’s a Tsunami!

Narendra Modi was due a late lie-in on 11 May. It was possibly the first Sunday in eight months when he didn’t have to hit the road and deliver another *bhashan* (speech). But for a swayamsevak, old habits die hard. Even though his first appointment was only after 8 a.m., Modi was up by 6, leafing through the morning newspapers and government files. I had been trying to speak to Modi for a fortnight now but to no avail. Normally, Modi would reply to a missed phone call. But in the rush of the last phase of campaigning, it seemed he had no time for even a short conversation. Vijay Nehra, additional secretary in the chief minister’s office, had promised that he would try and connect him on Sunday.

Finally, at around 10.30 a.m., the chief minister called back. ‘Should I be congratulating India’s next prime minister in advance!’ was my first response. I could hear a slight laugh on the other end. Our big post-poll survey results were to be out the next evening and Modi was anxious to know the findings. *‘Kya number de rahe ho, Rajdeep?’* (What number are you giving?), he asked. ‘My sense is our final number will be anything between 270 and 280, sir,’ I told him reassuringly.

Modi didn’t seem too pleased. ‘We will reach 300 seats—wave *hai*, wave,’ he said. I agreed with him. ‘Yes, I also feel 300 is the likely figure, you are sweeping north and west India, sir.’ *‘Yeh jo Dilli main baithe political pundit hain, inko kaho studio ke bahar jaaye!’* (Ask your Delhi-based experts to move out of the studio), he suggested. And then he suddenly broke into English. ‘First time since 1984, you will have a majority government in Delhi.’